

The First Indochina War

The war fought between the French Expeditionary Force and Viet Minh guerrillas from 1946 to 1954 was a brutal attritional struggle. The French were able to hold the major cities but suffered heavy losses defending outposts in territory dominated by the guerrillas.

◀◀ BEFORE

After World War II, the French hoped to reassert their great power status.

THE FRENCH UNION

In the **power vacuum** that existed in Indochina in the final stages of World War II, Ho Chi Minh declared **Vietnam independent**. However, after the war, France sought to regain its colonies, rebranding its empire as the French Union. They wanted to keep overall control while granting limited self-government. Ho Chi Minh rejected the proposal and in November 1946 launched a **guerrilla campaign** against the French.

In the immediate aftermath of the fighting in Hanoi that opened the war in December 1946, French generals believed the Viet Minh could be eliminated in a single punitive action. Taking the offensive in 1947, they forced the guerrillas to take refuge in the remote northern border region, but failed to destroy them.

Until 1949, the Viet Minh remained a manageable problem for the French, but the communist victory in China that year changed the situation. Armed and trained by the Chinese, the Viet Minh went on the attack. In September and October 1950, General Vo Nguyen Giap ordered offensives against French fortified bases along the Chinese border, from Cao Bang to Lang Son. All the outposts were overrun or abandoned and the French withdrawal turned into a rout.